9 Types of Layouts

After learning about float and clear, designing CSS based layouts should be very easy. A key factor in choosing a layout is the audience. Not every visitor to your web site will have the same browser. They will not share an identical screen resolution, but will definitely have their browser windows at varying widths. You have to begin to design for the lowest common denominator. We will examine some of the most common approaches to CSS layout with particular emphasis on flexibility and cross-browser performance. Deciding which layout is best for your web site is entirely up to you.

We'll investigate something called the Box Model, with specific regard to margin and padding, and how to get your columns to behave when viewed with older browsers. The various types of layouts include fixed width, liquid, elastic, and variable fixed width, for starters. Then there are other decisions to be made: should there be two, three, or four columns, and should the columns be floated or positioned? We will examine just a few of the possible options available to get a basic idea.

9.1 Different types of layouts

9.1.1 Fixed

A fixed-width layout has its total width and the widths of its columns defined using static width measurements, typically pixels. A fixed-width layout does not stretch to fill the browser window, and remains its set width. By having a predetermined width for the whole layout and its columns, you can be certain that the window width and screen resolution will not compromise the design, specifically with regard to carefully measured internal elements such as banners, images, and positioned text.

But, this also means that whatever width you declare is served to everyone. A 780-pixel-width design might look great on an 800×600 screen resolution, but it starts to look a bit dwarfed on the more common widescreen laptop screens with a 1280×1024 screen resolution. Also, anyone viewing your site with a viewport of less than 780 pixels is going to get horizontal scrollbars.

9.1.2 Liquid

A liquid (or fluid) layout expands and contracts to fill the browser window. Typically the columns will have widths declared using percentage measurements,